PRODUCT INTERN ASSIGNMENT — 2026

Subspace.money

A 5-Pillar Product Teardown

Submitted by	**Shishir Agarwal**
Assignment	**Product Intern — Subspace.money 2026**
Company chosen	**Subspace.money**
Submission date	**May 31, 2026**
Deadline	**Sunday, May 31, 2026, 11:59 PM IST**

UX	Features	GTM & ICP	Competitor	Collaboration

BEFORE WE GET TO BUSINESS, I wanna tell How I Approached This

Before even downloading the app, I noticed Subspace had a 3.5-star Play Store rating. Most apps cluster at 4.0+, so 3.5 is a structural signal, not a few unhappy users. **This rating is enough to turn away a large mass of audience which rely on ratings as ratings represent the trust of an application in general.** My first curiosity was to find what was driving that rating. So, I started my analyzation

I filtered the Play Store to 1-star reviews sorted by "Most Relevant" and read every one. A clear pattern emerged: ***shared subscriptions group admins removing users after payment with no refund, gift cards stuck in processing for days, app crashing on launch, and money locked in wallets with no easy withdrawal.***

The most-upvoted review (10 helpful votes the highest visible) revealed something deeper: an admin had retaliated against a user who left a negative review by removing them from groups and coordinating 1-star ratings against them. ***That is not a support failure. That is a platform integrity crisis.***

With that context I downloaded the app and used it as a real user, homepage, onboarding, gift card purchase flow, cart, wallet top-up, UPI payment. I documented specific screens, copy, and flows, noting where the experience broke relative to what the product promised. **Key bugs I found personally: the Rs.100 quick-select on a Dominos gift card added Rs.425 to cart instead; the cart count badge keeps incrementing even with 1 item; tapping a UPI app in Subspace's custom picker triggers Android's native intent chooser again, two selections for one action, creating unnecessary friction and redundance.**

Finally, I looked at Subspace's external presence. LinkedIn: 3,484 followers, 5-6 reactions per post. The most recent post promotes renting "premium gear for a photoshoot", a persona with zero overlap with the hostel student splitting a Netflix bill. Instagram: 906 followers, generic discount content. No clear ICP in either channel**. I see an immediate need for proper social media marketing and brand building.**

Everything that follows is grounded in what I actually saw and used. Generative AI has been used mainly for graphical documentation and not for research and task completion.

Company Snapshot

Founded	**2021, Bengaluru - IIT Madras founders (I am also doing BS in Data Science from IITM so ehm ehm)**
Core product	**Subscription sharing · Gift cards · 10-min rentals**
ARR	**Rs. 36.5 Cr (FY25) -bootstrapped, zero external funding. Even a small crunch can affect the overall company funding.**
Team size	**11-50 employees (LinkedIn)**
Key moat claimed	**Negotiate API · India-first · Subscription marketplace**
Play Store rating	**~3.5 stars - meaningful gap vs category average of 4.0+**

The Five Feedbacks

01

UX PILLAR

The checkout journey has three sequential friction points that kill conversion

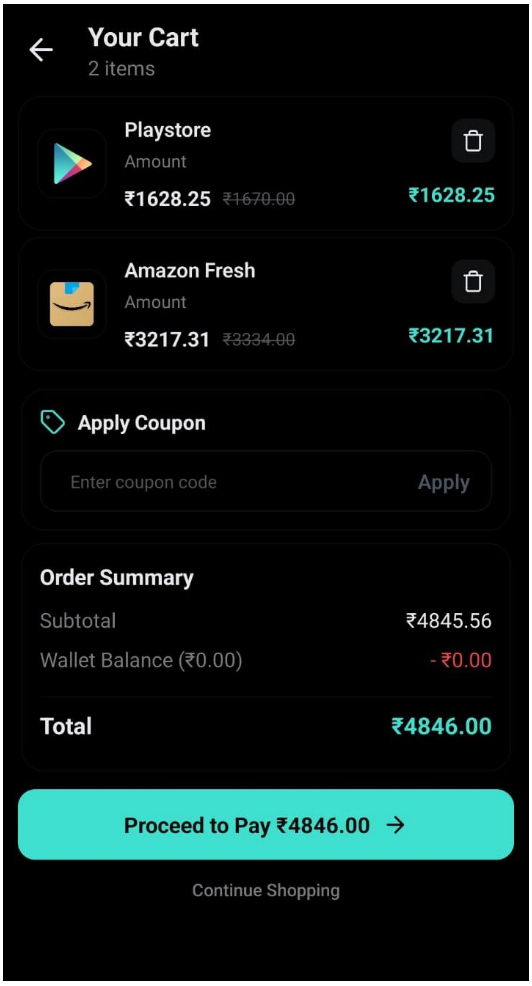
(o) OBSERVED

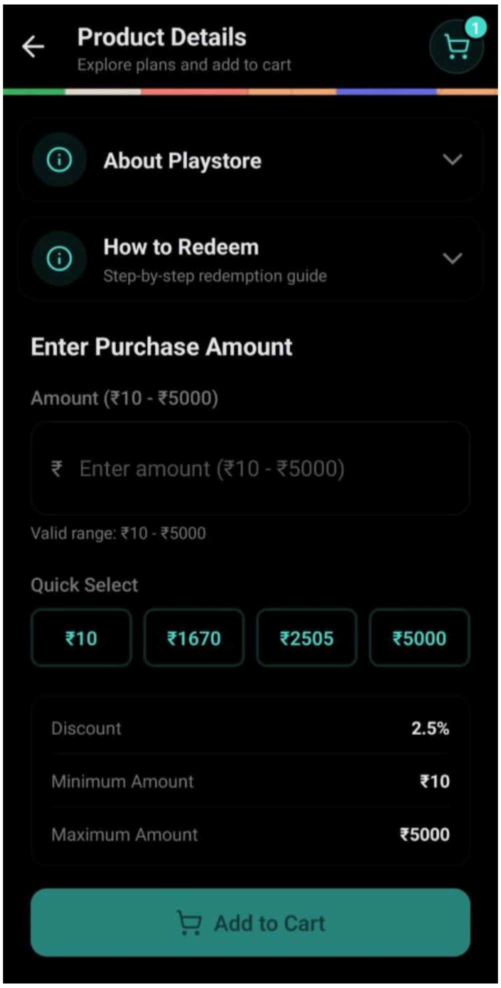
Three distinct UX failures were found in the purchase and payment flow, all within the same user journey:

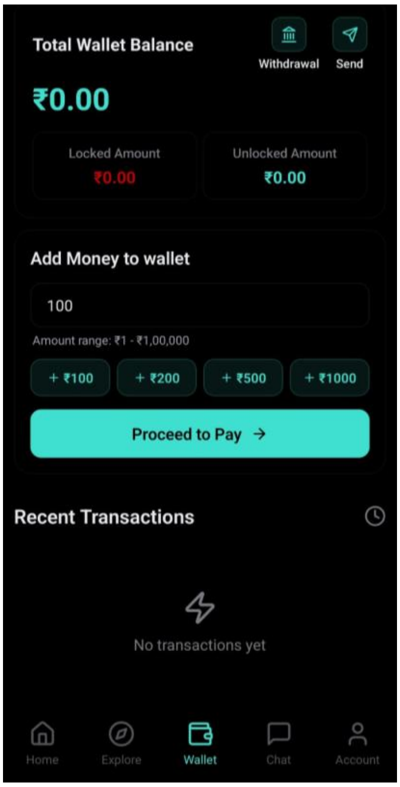
1. No "Buy Now" button on the cart screen (Exhibit A). The cart shows multiple items across categories with a single action: "Proceed to Pay Rs.4846." To buy just one item a user must delete all others, checkout, then re-add them, 6+ extra taps for a single purchase.

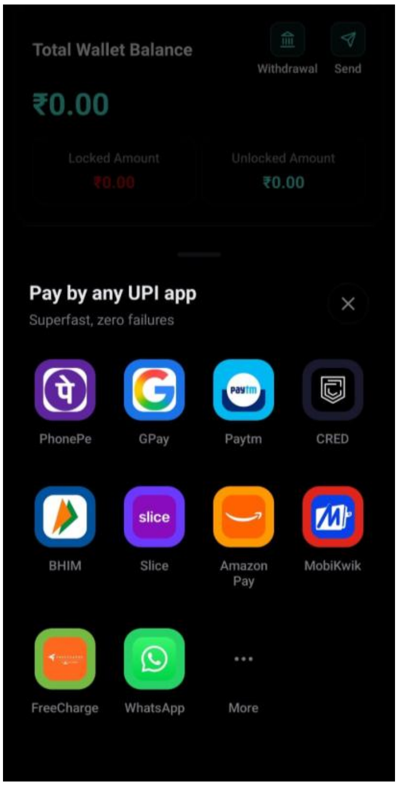
2. Non-intuitive quick-select amounts on the gift card product page (Exhibit B). Values shown: Rs.10 / Rs.1670 / Rs.2505 / Rs.5000. These are internal plan values surfaced directly to the user with no rounding or UX translation. Why Rs.2505 and not Rs.2500, like what is up with these random numbers anyway?

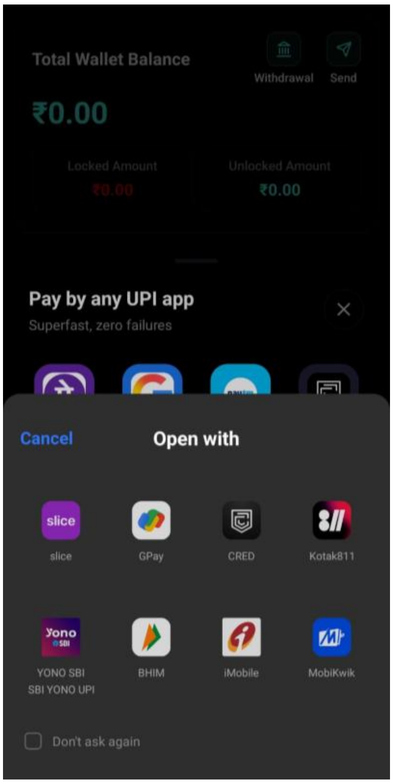
3. Double UPI selector (Exhibits C, D and E). Tapping "Proceed to Pay" on the wallet screen shows Subspace's custom UPI picker - tagline: "Superfast, zero failures." Selecting an app (e.g. CRED or Slice) then triggers Android's native "Open with" intent chooser. The user selects twice to do one action. The irony of "zero failures" on the screen that itself creates friction is notable.











(p) PROBLEM

These are not cosmetic issues; they compound at the highest-stakes moment in the product: when a user is about to pay. Each friction point independently increases drop-off probability; together they make checkout slower and more confusing than every major competitor: CRED Store (one-tap gift card), Amazon Pay (instant UPI with no intermediary), PhonePe (native intent directly). For a product whose core promise is saving money effortlessly, a laborious checkout flow is a direct brand contradiction. Gift cards are frequently impulse purchases; extra taps kill impulse conversion.

(s) SHIP INSTEAD

Fix 1: Add a “Buy Now” button on each cart item. Tapping it bypasses the multi-item cart and initiates direct checkout for that item only. Standard e-commerce pattern (Amazon, Flipkart). Engineering estimate: 3-5 days.

Fix 2: Replace non-intuitive quick-select values with round numbers: Rs.100 / Rs.500 / Rs.1000 / Rs.2000 / Rs.5000. Map internal plan values to user-friendly amounts in the UI layer. Lessens the confusion and bad UI.

Fix 3: Remove Subspace’s custom UPI selector entirely. Trigger Android’s native intent chooser directly when the user taps “Proceed to Pay.” This is An easy change and eliminates the double-selection entirely.

02

FEATURES / SERVICES PILLAR

A broken cart and a missing Access Guarantee create real financial risk for users

(o) OBSERVED

Two critical bugs found during live testing, plus a structural feature gap confirmed by multiple 1-star reviews:

Bug 1: Wrong amount added to cart (Exhibit H represents the screen recording of the glitch): On the Dominos gift card product page, minimum purchase is displayed as Rs.100 and a "Quick Select Rs.100" button is shown. Tapping Rs.100 added Rs.425 to the cart. Reproduced consistently.

Bug 2: Cart count badge mismatch: After clearing the cart and adding a single item, the cart badge count kept incrementing beyond 1. Cart state is not syncing with displayed count. **(Shown in Exhibit H)**

Structural gap NO ACCESS GUARANTEE: Multiple 1-star reviews describe the same failure: user pays for subscription access (Amazon Prime, Netflix), admin revokes access or removes them from the group, no automated refund issued. The most-upvoted review (10 helpful votes) reveals a platform-level exploit: admins retaliate against users who leave negative reviews by removing them from groups and coordinating 1-star ratings against them.

REVIEWS ARE ATTACHED AT THE END TO MAINTAIN DOCUMENT FLOW.

(p) PROBLEM

Bug 1 is not a UI glitch, in a fintech product, showing Rs.100 but charging Rs.425 is a financial integrity failure. A user who doesn't check the cart total will be overcharged by Rs.325 without knowing it. Combined with the cart count mismatch, the UI cannot be trusted to reflect actual purchase state.

The Access Guarantee gap is the most strategically dangerous issue in the product. Subspace's core moat is the group-sharing network, but if users get burned once (losing Rs.399 on a Netflix slot they lose access to), word spreads and network effects reverse. The reviews confirm this is not a rare edge case. At Rs.36.5 Cr ARR, even 5% trust-driven churn is a material revenue impact, and it compounds via negative word-of-mouth.

(s) SHIP INSTEAD

Bug 1 fix: Quick select buttons must correctly pass the selected amount to the cart addition API call. The current bug suggests the amount parameter is hardcoded or defaulting to the first plan value. Standard fix: 1-2 days of engineering time.

Bug 2 fix: Implement server-side cart count as the source of truth. Remove local state increment logic entirely.

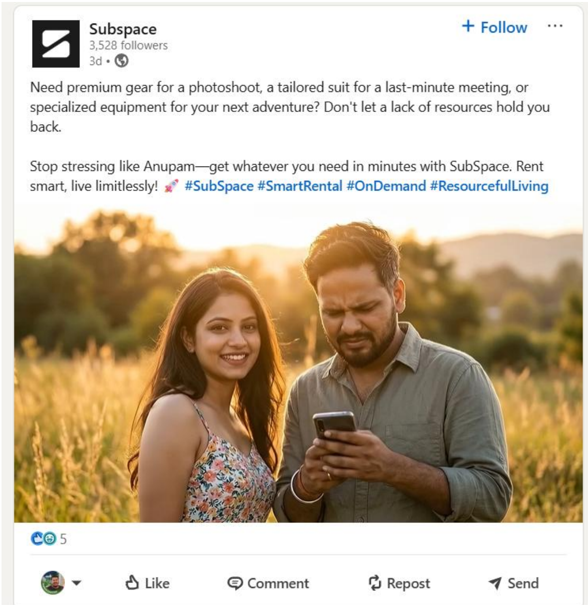
Access Guarantee: Introduce payment escrow or a locked wallet for subscription sharing. Payment is held in escrow and released to the admin only after the subscriber confirms active access. If the admin revokes access within the paid subscription period, an automatic pro-rated refund is issued to the subscriber's Subspace wallet. Engineering estimate: 2-3 weeks. This converts the #1 negative review pattern into a competitive differentiator: the only subscription-sharing platform in India where your money is always protected. Although, I saw a locked amount column in the wallet, I am stating a solution I deem necessary.

03 GTM & ICP PILLAR

Subspace is messaging three different people at once and converting none efficiently

(o) OBSERVED

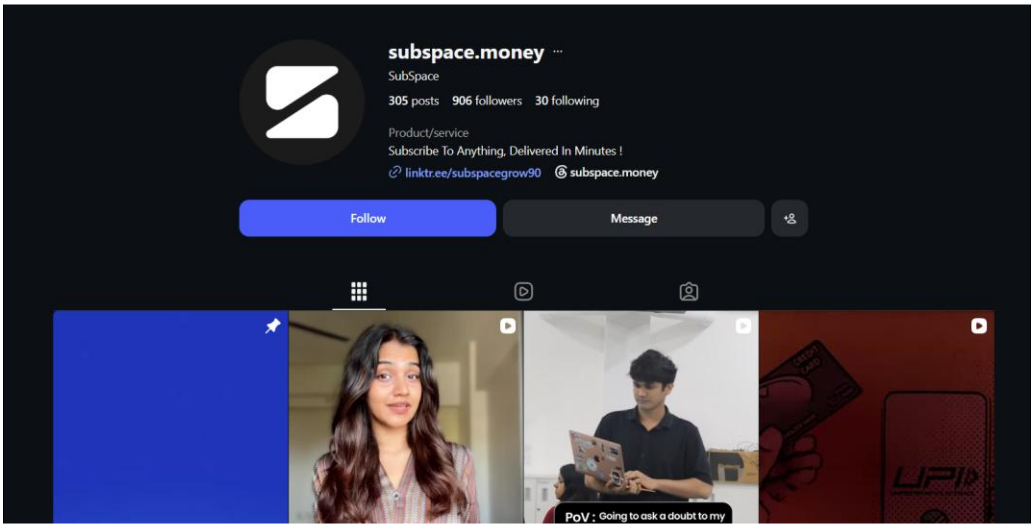
LinkedIn (3,484 followers, ~5-6 reactions per post): The most recent post promotes renting “premium gear for a photoshoot, a tailored suit for a last-minute meeting, or specialized equipment for your next adventure” - hashtags #SmartRental #OnDemand #ResourcefulLiving. This is a premium urban professional persona (Exhibit F).



Instagram (906 followers): Content covers gift card discounts and reducing recurring costs, a deal-seeker persona. No consistent visual identity or recurring content format (Exhibit G).

Play Store listing: Simultaneously targets students (college email deal), subscription sharers (OTT at 80% off), renters (gadgets with 10-min delivery), gift card buyers (200+ brands), and B2B subscription providers (marketplace listing). Five distinct audiences, one listing.

Homepage tagline: “Your subscription management platform”, but the first interaction is a delivery address modal for the rental feature.



(p) PROBLEM

When you speak to everyone, you convert no one at full efficiency. The LinkedIn rental post targets a persona with zero overlap with the hostel student splitting a Netflix bill, yet both are reached with the same product and brand. This fragmented messaging has two direct consequences: (1) higher Customer Acquisition Cost, as every rupee is split across incompatible audiences; (2) lower activation rates, because users who arrive from a "save 80% on Netflix" ad encounter a homepage that asks for their delivery address first. ROAS needs to be looked upon carefully. The social media marketing needs a proper framework and skilled experience.

The 906 Instagram followers and 5 LinkedIn reactions are not just vanity metrics, they are evidence that the current messaging is not resonating with any persona strongly enough to build an engaged community, despite Rs.36.5 Cr ARR suggesting real product-market fit exists somewhere, and this number even with such a low efficient marketing, can be revamped to a much higher number with effective social media marketing.

(s) SHIP INSTEAD

Lock the ICP for top-of-funnel acquisition to: "Urban college student, 18-24, living in a hostel or PG, sharing OTT subscriptions with 3-5 friends, price-sensitive." This segment has built-in virality (shares with batch-mates), low CAC (reachable via college communities and hostel WhatsApp groups), and high retention (4-year academic lifecycle).

Rebuild Instagram around concrete, shareable content for this persona: "4 friends, 1 Netflix account, each pays Rs.162", not abstract "reduce recurring costs." A/B test Reels vs static posts. Target: 5,000 followers in 90 days via organic college community sharing. As I mentioned, a proper social media targeted framework needs to be implemented ASAP.

Separate LinkedIn strategy for B2B subscription providers only. Stop promoting rentals on the main channels until that vertical has its own content identity. Measure CAC per segment for 60 days and double down on the shortest payback.

04

COMPETITOR ANALYSIS PILLAR

CRED has entered Subspace's subscription tracking lane WHILE Subspace has no counter-positioning

(o) OBSERVED

CRED launched "CRED Money" in July 2024: recurring payment reminders, unified bank account balance tracking via the RBI's Account Aggregator (AA) framework, and subscription spend analysis. CRED has 12 million+ credit-score-verified, premium users.

Subspace's website, Play Store listing, LinkedIn posts, and Instagram content contain zero acknowledgment of this. No "vs CRED" positioning, no feature differentiation messaging, no counter-narrative.

Simultaneously, Subspace's gift card vertical puts it in direct competition with CRED Store, Woohoo (SBI Card India's largest gift card marketplace), Amazon Pay, and PhonePe, all of which have structural trust advantages (bank tie-ups, daily-use apps, reward integrations) that a bootstrapped team cannot match on brand alone.

See Competitor Analysis table on following page

(p) PROBLEM

Subspace is fighting a two-front competitive war without a defensive strategy. From above, CRED is moving into subscription visibility with institutional trust and a premium user base. From below, P2P sharing apps like PlayBucks are copying the core model.

The gift card vertical is the most dangerous strategic choice. Subspace's only competitive lever there is price discount (2.5-10%), which CRED Store, Woohoo, and Amazon Pay can match or exceed. Investing engineering and marketing resources in gift cards means deprioritising the one thing only Subspace can do: P2P group subscription sharing with the Negotiate API.

CRED's structural limitation is that it cannot easily offer P2P group sharing (it is a credit-gated, individual-user product). That gap is Subspace's strategic window, but it closes if Subspace does not claim it explicitly. Also, CRED maintains friction point that you will need to first verify a credit card to proceed, this is where subspace wins majorly.

(s) SHIP INSTEAD

Run explicit counter-positioning against CRED: "CRED tells you what you spend. Subspace gets you out of it cheaper." Build a comparison landing page. This is a copywriting and design sprint, no new engineering required.

Make the Negotiate API a headline brand feature, not a backend detail. This invites new interests and first movers to notice the brand as first movers notice technology than marketing words. It is genuinely hard to replicate and no competitor offers it, yet it is buried in marketing materials. Lead with it on the homepage and Play Store listing**. MAKE THIS A BIG DEAL. THIS INVITES INVESTORS AND TECH ENTHUSIASTS. EVEN IF YOU DON'T HIRE ME, KEEP THIS ON TOP.**

Strategically de-emphasise gift cards in marketing spend. The vertical can remain as a conversion feature within the app, but should not be a primary GTM channel where Subspace has no durable moat. See Competitor Analysis table on the following page.

05

POTENTIAL COLLABORATIONS PILLAR

Subspace’s best users already live together, but aren’t being activated as a cluster. THIS IS GOLD, JUST GIVE IT A READ.

(o) OBSERVED

Subspace offers a student email signup bonus (called out in the Play Store listing **as “Extra deals for students who sign up with a college email”)** and has both private and public group-sharing functionality. **However, there is no formal hostel or PG partnership, no campus ambassador program, and no in-app social graph feature that maps to real-world co-living arrangements. Look at perplexity, they offered campus ambassador programs and comet has become one of the top used browsers in India. Experience hungry students go crazy for these opportunities. Use them.**

The group creation flow requires users to manually invite others. There is no suggestion engine based on location, institution, or co-living proximity. Subspace acquires students one-by-one through paid ads, even when those students live on the same hostel floor and already share Wi-Fi, food, and OTT subscriptions.

(p) PROBLEM

The highest-density Subspace user cluster, college students in hostels and PGs, already exists as a physical community. My hostel alone had around 5000 boys living under a 5 acre area. Subspace pays Customer Acquisition Cost for each member of that community individually, when the social graph already exists and the willingness to share subscriptions is already established.

The current student targeting (college email discount) is a discount tactic, not a distribution strategy. It reduces per-unit CAC marginally without unlocking the cluster-acquisition flywheel. If Subspace acquires entire floors or hostels as a unit, retention is socially reinforced, a student is far less likely to churn if their entire floor is on Subspace.

(s) SHIP INSTEAD

Partner with Stanza Living, OYO Rooms (PG division), or NestAway, which collectively house hundreds of thousands of students across Bengaluru, Pune, Delhi, and Hyderabad. Offer Subspace as a built-in move-in amenity: every resident is onboarded to a pre-configured “House Subspace” group for their floor or property. The hostel operator absorbs acquisition cost (Subspace credits bundled as a room perk, similar to Wi-Fi), and Subspace receives dense social-graph clusters with a natural 12-24 month retention window tied to the academic year.

This is an operations and partnerships sprint, not an engineering build. A pilot can run in one Bengaluru property within 30 days, or try a private university with a huge amount of students. Success metric: compare 90-day retention of hostel-acquired cohorts vs ad-acquired cohorts. If retention uplift is 20%+, this becomes the primary acquisition channel for the student ICP.

Competitor Analysis Table

Subspace operates across three verticals, facing different competitors in each. The table below maps the competitive landscape across dimensions most relevant to Subspace's moat and strategic positioning.

Feature / Dimension	Subspace	CRED	Splitwise	Fi Money	PlayBucks
P2P Subscription Sharing	Yes	No	No	No	Yes
Gift Cards	Yes	Yes	No	No	No
Expense / Sub Tracking	Partial	Yes	Yes	Yes	No
Negotiate API	Yes	No	No	No	No
Access Guarantee / Escrow	No	N/A	N/A	N/A	No
India-first Design	Yes	Yes	No	Yes	Yes
Brand Trust	Medium	Very High	High	High	Low
User Base	Growing	12M+	50M+ global	Growing	Small
Bootstrapped / Profitable	Yes	No	No	No	No

Many PARTS OF ABOVE TABLE WERE RESEARCHED AND RETRIEVED FROM AI TOOLS.

> **Key insight:** Subspace's only truly differentiated feature is P2P subscription sharing combined with the Negotiate API. No other player in the Indian market offers both. Every other vertical Subspace has entered, gift cards, expense tracking, rentals, has at least one better-resourced competitor. The strategic imperative is to dominate the one thing only Subspace can do before expanding further.

Prioritization Logic, (hire me and this is what we shall work with from day 1, or maybe day 2 if day 1 is all introduction and onboarding)

Subspace is bootstrapped with a small team. Every product decision is a resource allocation decision. Here is how I would sequence the five feedbacks:

1

Fix Cart Bugs + Launch Access Guarantee [Features]

Timeline: 2-3 weeks

Financial integrity bugs must be fixed before any growth spend. A user who gets overcharged or loses subscription access tells five friends, that negative word-of-mouth compounds and is the hardest thing to recover from at Subspace's stage. The Access Guarantee converts the #1 negative review pattern into a competitive moat.

2

Fix Double UPI Selector + Add Buy Now Button [UX]

Timeline: 3-5 days

Lowest effort, highest checkout conversion impact. The UPI selector fix is a single-line change. Buy Now requires ~1 week of engineering. Both directly improve payment completion rates at zero additional CAC. THIS IS VERY NECESSARY TBH I FELT SO FRICTIONED AND IRRITATED WITH NO BUY NOW BUTTON.

3

ICP Refocus + Instagram Content Strategy [GTM & ICP]

Timeline: 2 weeks

Zero engineering cost: a marketing and content sprint only. Rebuilding Instagram around the student ICP compounds over time. Assign one person for 2 weeks. Measure follower growth and activation rate from organic student community sharing.

4

CRED Counter-Positioning + Negotiate API as Headline Feature [Competitor]

Timeline: 1 week

Positioning sprint only: build a comparison landing page, rewrite homepage hero to lead with the Negotiate API. No engineering beyond copywriting and one landing page. Must be done before CRED iterates further into subscription tracking.

5

Hostel / PG Partnership Pilot [Collaboration]

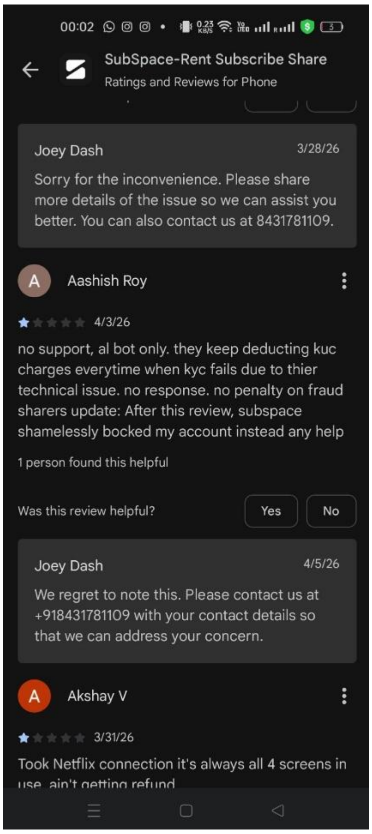
Timeline: 30-day pilot

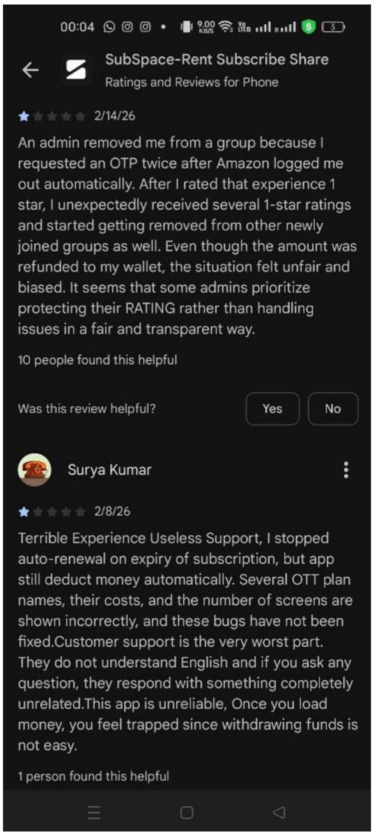
Highest long-term LTV impact but requires ops bandwidth. Run a 30-day pilot in one Bengaluru property to validate retention uplift before full rollout. If 90-day retention of hostel-acquired cohorts exceeds ad-acquired by 20%+, this becomes the primary acquisition channel.

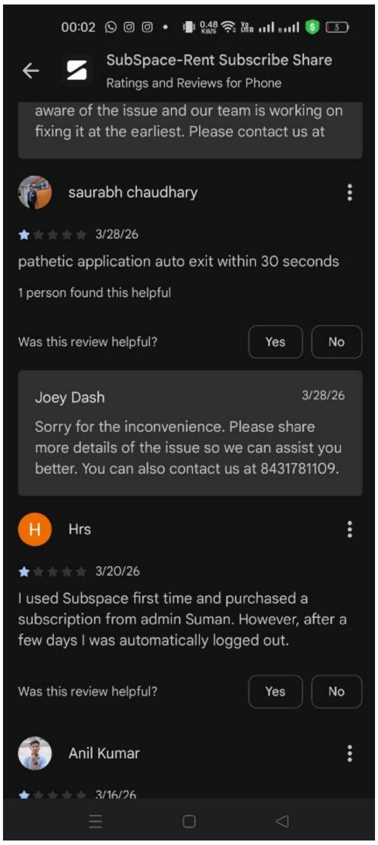
> *I would prioritize #1 regardless of effort: financial integrity bugs in a fintech product erode trust faster than any other failure mode. Fix that first, then grow.*

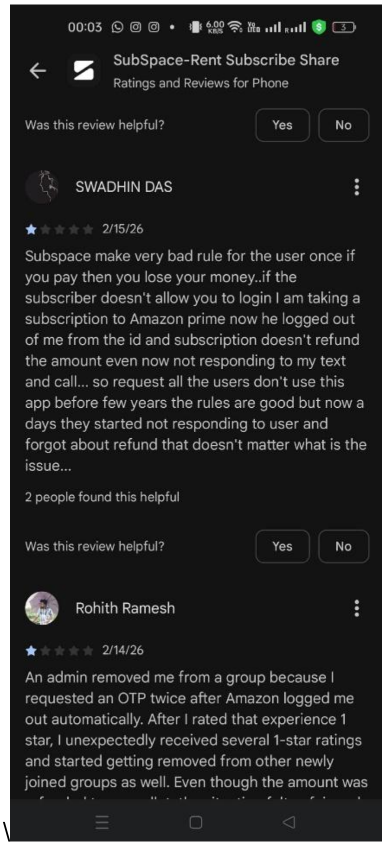
Appendix: Screenshot Exhibits

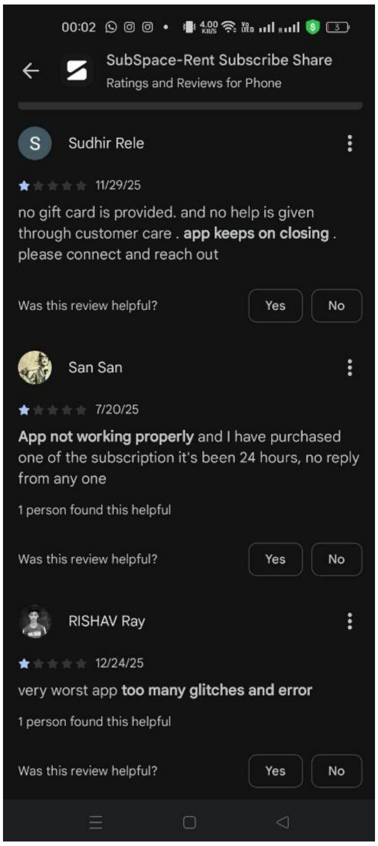
All screenshots were captured during live app testing on May 30-31, 2026, and from the Subspace Play Store review section (filtered: Most Relevant, 1-star).

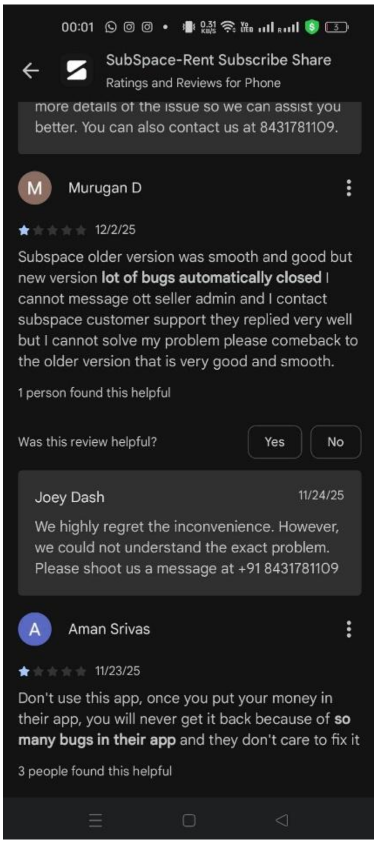












00:01

SubSpace-Rent Subscribe Share
Ratings and Reviews for Phone

Was this review helpful? Yes No

Joey Dash 4/2/26

Sorry for the inconvenience caused. We're aware of the issue and our team is working on fixing it at the earliest. Please contact us at

Amar Sharma

4/6/26

These people are scammer, first their app **doesn't work most of the times**, i had already cancelled my subscription still money got deducted and now when i am trying to withdraw money that is also not working, this app is toal scammer, never install this app.

2 people found this helpful

Was this review helpful? Yes No

Joey Dash 3/28/26

Sorry for the inconvenience. Please share more details of the issue so we can assist you better. You can also contact us at 8431781109.

Murugan D

12/2/25

14:16

SubSpace-Rent Subscribe Share
Ratings and Reviews for Phone

Was this review helpful? Yes No

SWADHIN DAS

2/15/26

Subspace make very bad rule for the user once if you pay then you lose your money..if the subscriber doesn't allow you to login I am taking a subscription to Amazon prime now he logged out of me from the id and subscription doesn't refund the amount even now not responding to my text and call... so request all the users don't use this app before few years the rules are good but now a days they started not responding to user and forgot about refund that doesn't matter what is the issue...

2 people found this helpful

Was this review helpful? Yes No

Pawan Kolli

4/14/26

Purchased gift Card in the app and they provided invalid gift card.They are not giving the refund even after 3 months follow up.

1 person found this helpful

14:16

SubSpace-Rent Subscribe Share
Ratings and Reviews for Phone

Parminder Singh

1/19/26

I paid for a subscription through their app and they messaged saying that I'll get the subscription in a day and then 15 days later I still haven't gotten the subscription and they are not bothered to give their service. this is a fraudulent practice and should be reported.

5 people found this helpful

Was this review helpful? Yes No

Jatin Agnihotri

1/11/26

Getting no response from the support team. Raised the issue multiple times. On the support team doesn't reply at all. Locked amount is not decreasing as it used to be decreased per day. From the last few days is constant.

2 people found this helpful

Was this review helpful? Yes No

Mihir Makadia

5/14/26

14:16

SubSpace-Rent Subscribe Share
Ratings and Reviews for Phone

Was this review helpful? Yes No

Pawan Kolli

4/14/26

Purchased gift Card in the app and they provided invalid gift card.They are not giving the refund even after 3 months follow up.

1 person found this helpful

Was this review helpful? Yes No

Joey Dash 4/19/26

Hi, sorry for the inconvenience. This isn't the experience we aim for. Please contact us at +91 8431781109 or share your number—we'll

Parminder Singh

1/19/26

I paid for a subscription through their app and they messaged saying that I'll get the subscription in a day and then 15 days later I still haven't gotten the subscription and they are not bothered to give their service. this is a fraudulent practice and should be reported.

5 people found this helpful

23:42

SubSpace-Rent Subscribe Share
Ratings and Reviews for Phone

Rajendra Karmakar

5/19/26

I bought a gift card worth 1099 rupees for 1012.73 rupees but it got stucked in processing then I called the customer care at first they picked the call & after some seconds they cut the call then I tried another number they listened and told me it will be refunded shortly that short time turned into 3 days I have been nagged at home constantly I contacted them but they are like in just 5 min it will be done and now its not refunded till now I don't know when , plz resolve my issue

1 person found this helpful

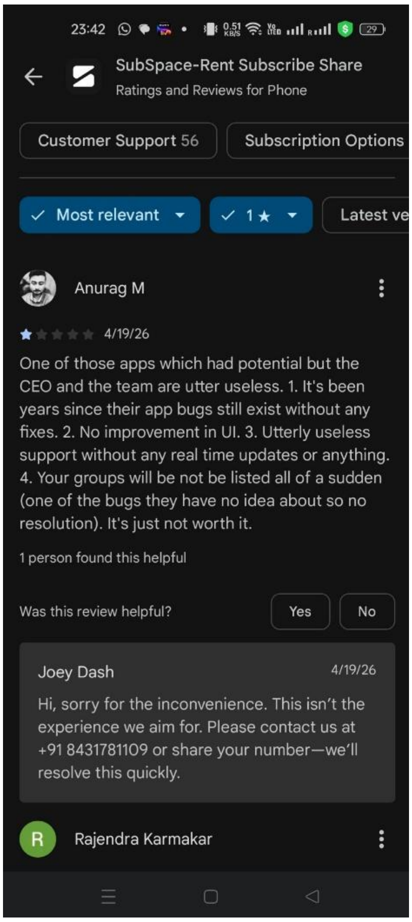
Was this review helpful? Yes No

Adi

5/17/26

i just bought jio hotstar gift card but there is no code its just saying processing its been 50 min already i tried to contact from the number i found on website at first they picked the call but after hearing they cut the call midway and not picking further calls if any team member seeing this plz help

Was this review helpful? Yes No



All observations in this report are based on direct app usage (May 30-31, 2026), Play Store review analysis, and public social media research. No AI-generated observations were included without personal verification by the author.